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Defence Diplomacy and Neighbourhood

As the army chief, I endeavoured to enhance our level of military cooperation with other countries within the ambit of the foreign policy parameters enunciated by the government, and contribute towards achievement of our national objectives. This was one of my key result areas. I laid down guidelines for augmenting the level of army-to-army cooperation and directed the newly created defence cooperation cell, which was an extension of the foreign division in the Army HQ, to identify the areas of mutual interest and make out a road map for defence cooperation with friendly countries. I undertook a number of goodwill visits as the army chief, and as the chairman of the chiefs of staff committee in my last year in office. My priorities were our immediate neighbours and countries with which we have a strategic partnership, followed by those with which we have traditional ties and enduring military relationships.

The experience gained by me during my tenure of three years as the defence attaché of India in our embassy in Algeria gave me valuable insights into the world of diplomacy. It also brought out the importance of military diplomacy as a vital component of our foreign policy. As is the case with other developed nations that have enshrined international defence cooperation as an important mission to further their national diplomatic aims, we also need to give this dimension a similar place. The need for defence cooperation, including an array of other activities such as high-level strategic dialogue and goodwill exchanges, joint training, sharing of intelligence relating to terrorism or other mutual security concerns, professional military courses of instruction, and weapons and equipment transfers, is unexceptionable. Furthermore, participation